

Page 1: Overview and Risk Factors

High blood pressure, also called hypertension, is blood pressure that is higher than normal. Blood pressure is measured using a blood pressure cuff.

Hypertension is classified into stages:

- Normal: Systolic less than 120 mmHg and diastolic less than 80 mmHg.
- Elevated: Systolic between 120-129 mmHg and diastolic less than 80 mmHg.
- Stage 1 Hypertension: Systolic between 130-139 mmHg or diastolic between 80-89 mmHg.
- Stage 2 Hypertension: Systolic 140 mmHg or higher or diastolic 90 mmHg or higher.
- Hypertensive Crisis: Systolic higher than 180 mmHg and/or diastolic higher than 120 mmHg. A hypertensive crisis requires immediate medical attention.

Major risk factors for developing hypertension include family history, older age, physical inactivity, a diet high in sodium (salt), and obesity.

Lifestyle modifications are critical components of high blood pressure prevention and control. Key recommended non-pharm

1. Dietary Changes:

- Follow the DASH (Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension) eating plan, which emphasizes fruits, vegetables, whole gr
- Limit sodium intake to less than 2,300 mg per day, with an ideal limit of 1,500 mg per day for most adults.
- Increase dietary potassium intake (3,500-5,000 mg/day) through potassium-rich foods like bananas, spinach, and sweet

2. Physical Activity:

- Engage in at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic exercise per week (e.g., brisk walking, swimming, or cyclin

3. Weight Management:

- Maintain a healthy body weight (BMI between 18.5 and 24.9 kg/m²). Expect a reduction of approximately 1 mmHg in blo

4. Alcohol and Smoking Cessation:

- Limit alcohol consumption to no more than 2 drinks per day for men and 1 drink per day for women.
- Complete cessation of cigarette smoking and tobacco product usage.

Regular blood pressure monitoring is essential for evaluating intervention efficacy. Adults diagnosed with Stage 1 or Stage 2

Warning Symptoms Requiring Urgent Care:

Patients experiencing any of the following severe symptoms alongside elevated blood pressure must seek immediate emergency care:

- Severe, sudden chest pain or pressure
- Sudden shortness of breath (dyspnea)
- Severe headache accompanied by confusion or blurred vision
- Sudden numbness, weakness, or difficulty speaking (signs of stroke)
- Nausea and vomiting associated with severe headache

Note: Patients should never alter or stop prescribed antihypertensive medications without direct consultation with their primary care provider.